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Sexual solidarity and the secrets of sight and sound

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Kapelach and Kipchornwonek Okiek, western Mau Escarpment, Rift Valley province, Kenya

Section Title(S)

sexual solidarity and the secrets of sight and sound

The tension between complementarity and hierarchy is found and produced not only in differences between boys' and girls' ceremonies, but also in aspects shared by both. What comes to the fore here is another side of Okiek conceptions of gender: the view of men as capable organizers, debaters, and decision-makers, and of women as children to be organized. Broad patterns of participation in the public ceremonies, for example, cast women as singers and performers of ritual acts, young people as singers or silent participants, and men as organizers and speakers. Okiek ideas about gender roles and relations are extended and expressed in these different kinds of ceremonial participation, bound up there with ideas about the power and expression of emotion. The participation patterns are also intrinsic to the dramatic development of the ceremonies (Kratz 1988b:459–460).

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Blessings by male elders, the most authoritative organizers by virtue of both gender and age, are the final auspicious ratification of ritual acts performed by others. In those blessings, the themes and mode of performance represent and temporarily create a version of the ideal life (Kratz 1988a). That ideal underlines women's reproductive role but passes mutely over their essential productive role, presenting no challenge to the hierarchical and patriarchal structures portrayed and legitimated. This silence is broken in seclusion. Songs sung daily by female initiates in seclusion and by adult women during ceremonies include call lines specifically about their productive activities, such as cutting firewood and grinding maize. Lessons and lectures in seclusion also touch on the productive responsibilities of each sex, appropriate relations between husband and wife, and certain essential

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relations of respect. For men, these relations of respect involve their mothers and fathers, elders, age-mates, and ritual teachers as well as the general ceremonial community of initiated men. For women, they center on husbands and fathers-in-law, along with older women, ritual teachers, and the general community of initiated women.

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Seclusion teachings for both boys and girls articulate and inculcate norms of conduct consonant with the male-oriented hierarchy, but in women's initiation they do so in a context that blatantly contradicts the assumptions on which it is based. Contrary to the image of women as incapable of making decisions, of cooperation, or of collective accomplishment, the ceremonies of seclusion actually demonstrate their ability for independent organization and action. That women's behavior in other situations actually conforms unflinching to norms of expected conduct is belied by the vehemence of some seclusion lectures to female initiates, especially regarding sexual fidelity and unquestioning obedience to their husbands. Their impassioned delivery gives special emphasis (often ineffectual) to these most problematic and commonly disregarded norms. Meyerhoff (1981:175) and H. Moore (1986:175ff.) both report that the teaching of Kalenjin-speaking Pokot and Marakwet girls in seclusion stresses patriarchal norms but is simultaneously full of explicit contradictions of those norms. I could not attend secret Okiek ceremonies, but in other contexts women's discussion of marital situations and relations certainly ran counter to the dominant and "official" view in some cases.

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Okiek women are usually separated in households, living with their husbands' families, and rarely come together as a group. It is significant, then, when they do gather to incorporate their daughters into the general community of adult women, from which men are excluded. These ceremonial gatherings are the primary occasions for constitution and reaffirmation of their unity as women in a ritual community. They are also a singular challenge to the received view of gender roles and relations. Yet that unified challenge is contextually confined, like Okiek reinterpretations of their relations with their neighbors when among themselves. For men, on the other hand, the meeting of their ritual community is but one gathering among many. In addition to ceremonial occasions, men of a wide area gather for legal-political meetings (to the exclusion of women). Smaller groups drawn from a variety of households also meet when they cooperate and share in forest work. Faced with the challenge of women's own corresponding  458 ritual community and ceremonial organization, men sometimes try to introduce an evaluative hierarchy and male priority into the trial and secrets of initiation as well. Some may claim that their pain is greater, or that shared themes in secret songs were taken from them by women. However, these attempts are usually joking or rather half-hearted, in partial recognition of their absurdity.

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